

8.6 Issues and debates	Examples of issues and debates in health psychology: • Ethical (e.g. the use of animals and humans when researching drugs and drug treatments like aversion therapy). • Practical issues in the design and implementation of research (e.g. generalising from findings from animal studies to human behaviour; studying drug action in the brain is hard to access holistically). • Reductionism (e.g. when considering the use of methods such as experiments; that studies using animals tend to isolate variables). • Comparisons between ways of explaining behaviour using different themes (e.g. different explanations for drug misuse, learning and biological). • Psychology as a science (e.g. using animal experiments to study drug misuse; considering biological explanations for drug misuse). • Culture (e.g. considering the cross-cultural research) and gender (not specifically considered in this topic area, though gender differences in drug taking could be considered). • Nature-nurture (e.g. learning as opposed to biological explanations for drug misuse). • An understanding of how psychological understanding has developed over time (e.g. rise of understanding about drug misuse – explanations for drug misuse; rising understanding used in anti-drug campaigns). • Issues of social control (e.g. treating drug misuse as criminal and requiring treatment). • The use of psychological knowledge within society (e.g. using understanding of drug misuse to develop treatment ideas). • Issues related to socially sensitive research (e.g. asking about drug 'habits' when people are vulnerable).
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